



Heroic campaign: Leading from the front all season, SG Pipers captain Navneet Kaur (R) was named Hero Player of the Tournament, earning the Rs. 20 lakh award for her standout show. R. V. MOORTHY

passers-by for photo opportunities, to a franchise PR manager unaware of where the team hotel was, the anecdotes bordered on the absurd.

Interviews with players suggest that the league's reputation in other hockey-playing nations remains mixed. "Everyone says 'planning' in India isn't really 'planning.' Things change often, and that happened on the second day itself. We were supposed to train in the evening.

And in the morning, our coach texted us saying we're playing a game at 2 p.m. So, things like that are really funny, but the girls are saying that it's improved since last year. Like the bus is now coming every time, on time. Apparently, sometimes they were kept waiting, and the bus never came," says Netherlands forward Sosha Benninga, who was initially sceptical about coming to the country after hearing stories of

players being made to travel on sleeper-class trains.

There is clearly more thought required before HIL-W can convincingly call itself a professional league rather than a well-intentioned event. For now, the tournament can take comfort in drawing sizeable crowds even on weekdays, despite the biting cold, largely on the strength of a solid advertising campaign.